

Appendix — Interview Transcripts

Designing for young men's everyday stress — semi-structured interviews, participants P1–P3

Anonymisation: participant names have been replaced throughout with the codes P1, P2 and P3. The researcher is identified only as “Interviewer”.

Cleaning: transcripts have been lightly cleaned for readability. Filler tokens and backchannel utterances (mhm, mm, umm, uh, oh, isolated “yeah” / “okay”), duplicated words produced by the auto-transcription, and empty or non-substantive turns have been removed. Consecutive turns by the same speaker have been merged. No wording has been added, reordered or paraphrased.

Timestamps refer to the start of each retained turn in the original recording.

Transcription artefacts in the source (for example “green fog”, “desertation”) have been left as recorded rather than corrected.

Participant P1

Recorded 27 August 2026 · duration 10 min 59 sec · 25 turns retained

Interviewer (0:08): So I like to understand how you respond to every difficult or stressful moments. You don't need to discuss anything deeply personal. And you can skip the question if you don't want to answer it. OK, the first question that I want to understand from you is, can you think of a recent time when you failed? Stressed or frustrated or low or not quite yourself like and what was happening at that time.

P1 (0:39): I think one of the standout ones from recently was when I had, when I ended up doing a bit of coursework overnight on the last night before it was due. Because I remember, you know, underestimating how difficult it was going to be, how much time it was going to do. To get that done. Because I remember it was due like 1:00 and it was about 6 AM. I'd sit up all night to do it and it was getting light out and I was really beginning to think, okay, am I going to get this done in time? So at that point, you just As like the hours went on, I think I got it done by like 11 AM, so it was like 2 hours spare. And I was just thinking, I had to feel like I had to like cut corners to get it done. I looked something, there was some data I think, that's not right, that's not how it's supposed to turn out, I was thinking. There's not really much time to change that now, I've just got to go with that.

Interviewer (1:42): And so how did you first notice that something wasn't right for you? Like, were you panicking or were your thoughts like way too flooded with all those questions regarding how you'll submit and stuff like that? What was it like at that point?

P1 (1:57): I think for me, I usually feel like kind of stressed. The way I kind of noticed that is like, I have this really hollow like feeling in my stomach, like, and also obviously my heart will go like a mile a minute. And that's usually what, so, and there were moments during that, especially near the end, where I've really had that feeling where, oh God, I'm not going to do this. Why did I put this off so long? And then At that point, it wasn't really, I didn't really feel like I could kind of take time to panic. I just kind of thought, I've just got to get this done because otherwise, every second count, I'm going to be completely, I'm going to be in trouble if I can't get it done.

Interviewer (2:26): But what do you think? Like, how did you respond in that moment and what made you choose like doing something that you did at that point in time?

P1 (2:37): I mean, I think, as with this example, since there was like a deadline, since I had to get it done, there was really a moment to kind of like sit back and, you know, take a breather, because I felt like at that

point I couldn't, I couldn't afford to. So like, I remember, obviously, once I got it sent off, even though I was thinking that was not the best work I've done, I was still thinking, oh, thank God, that's done. The time spare. It's actually impressed because I've heard from other people, a friend, I think, sent a work off, not even in the last minute as the clock turned over to the time. It was due.

Interviewer (3:27): But did that happen with you again? Did you do the same mistake again or it's like...

P1 (3:29): So, I think compare that to that. Yeah, I'll admit I've left pretty much every coursework to the last minute this year, the second year. And, but that was that was definitely the worst one, because you know, I had a good like 5 hours of leeway. I'd get done by like 6 AM, 7 AM. But that one in particular, where it really felt like it was down to the wire, and that was where I felt like a huge amount of stress. Well, so I was kind of kind of lost bits down for it.

Interviewer (3:56): But any reason that you procrastinated on it like for such a long time? Was it like something that you might not be interested in the subject or stuff like that?

P1 (4:18): It was really boring. It was research methods. I hate research methods. But it was also, there was some data handling that I remember, which was just, I just find that like going through tables, I just find that all so dull. I could never really will myself to get started with it, which didn't help because During that, I remember having to kind of like search up a bunch of YouTube videos to figure out what was actually being said with the data and how to interpret it, which, you know, adds on to the time. But I think I was just, I was just like, I just kept pulling it off. I could part of it was just thinking like, oh, I can get it done. Part of it was also me thinking that, like I said, underestimating how long it takes to do. So, just I could just bang this out in the night. It'll be easy. I'll get times there. Well, I was aware I was going to pull an all-nighter, but I don't think it was going to be like a matter of a few hours before I'd be able to hand it in.

Interviewer (4:59): So is there any activity or something that you do when you feel stressed or it's like you just go blank or something or you don't know what to do next or you're just stuck there?

P1 (5:27): Usually, if I kind of feel stressed, I usually do like to kind of take a break, do something I enjoy, like, you know, reading, gaming, that kind of thing. But I feel like usually if I am, I kind of like kind of like kind of clutch my heart so I can actually feel the kind of feel it going and that I think kind of like grounds me, just like being aware of it, like physically affects me and thinking, yeah, okay, go slow it down, got to calm down. Obviously, in that scenario, I couldn't really do that, but I got through it.

Interviewer (5:56): So is it is it more like you get the signs more physically or like do you have signs when it comes to like you feel stressed in your mind or it's like body or you have both the symptoms like it's the mind as well the body as well like. How do you feel when you are stressed? Like, does it comes more from a bodily experience or like my full experience?

P1 (6:18): I mean, during stress, I do get the kind of thoughts like, oh, I can't do this. Oh, I never should have done this or that. I should have done this differently. But I do think I do feel it more like kind of physically, like that, like that kind of hollow feeling in my stomach. Like that's like if I feel like I think, okay, yeah, this is really stressing me out. What's going on here?

Interviewer (6:33): And if that happens, like how do you usually respond? Like, so suppose for example, like recently I was not doing well because of family situations back then. So I sort of started procrastinating on sleeping more or Just, yeah, just avoiding everything at that point. But is it usually like that or do you like to deal with it at the very same time or do you take time for it in order to process it and then deal with it? Like, do you like to have a solution of what you're feeling or is it? Just get over it like it'll pass or something like that.

P1 (7:29): I think I usually have the kind of mindset that it will pass. I've just got to like kind of slow down, give it time. I, like, I do think that I kind of like shut myself more up in like my room and stuff. I'm feeling particularly stressed and stuff like I'll probably just spend more time in bed. It's great there.

Interviewer (7:34): Have you tried off like going out for a walk or something just in order to release whatever you're feeling or anything like that? Just for like doing a physical activity or more engaging in nature so that it just calms you down, something like that?

P1 (8:03): How do you find that kind of doing like some sort of exercise does help with doing it? Because I remember for another bit of course, like which I also left at the last minute, when I got that done once I was finished, I may just went to the gym, just kind of like kind of decompress from that.

Interviewer (8:09): Like usually people like pretty much want to like just release those like nervous system points, like in order to just feel calm and relaxed and bit more themselves like that. I think. So if any similar situation happens, like when you are stressed, Do you like in a way try to make sense of it? Like where it is coming from and how frequent it happens? Or is it just like because of the deadlines and everything, you're just more stressed? Or is it like a... more like a situational thing rather than just one particular thing.

P1 (9:11): I think it's, I think that the kind of the stuff that's kind of stressed about can, it can come from anywhere, it kind of depends. But, and when I kind of do feel that I'm not really thinking about solutions, just kind of thinking, I'll just, you know, I'll They'll take it easy, I'll get, and eventually it will pass, I'll get over it, and then... Carry on, car, carry on.

Interviewer (9:37): So, but if you had a chance to understand where it's building up from and anything, so would you like to know that where it's building up from and what's actually triggering it and stuff like that?

P1 (10:02): For that kind of thing. I think with, after the kind of stress and stuff has passed, I do kind of think, okay, that probably came from there, like this game probably came from because of the deadlines or from wherever else. So yeah, that's a...

Interviewer (10:04): That was pretty much it. I just wanted to know how your pattern, like what do you do and what do you deal with when it comes to like pressure or like stress. So yeah, makes sense. Thank you so much, P1.

P1 (10:42): Of course, same time.

Interviewer (10:44): That's from Aabjeet. I'll stop the recording.

Participant P2

Recorded 27 August 2026 · duration 12 min 27 sec · 34 turns retained

Interviewer (0:06): So the entire problem statement, like what I want to know from you is like, how do you respond to everyday difficult or stressful moments? And you don't need to discuss anything deeply personal. And if you want, you can skip the question as well. So first question is, Can you think of a recent time when you feel stressed, frustrated, no, or not quite yourself? Or you had like an unpleasant feeling? And what was happening at that time?

P2 (0:31): In terms of what I was feeling? I think the most recent stress was about a lot of things happening at once. Finding new accommodation, desertation deadlines and all of that. It does get your head sometimes when you're not getting any kind of input from either. So it the stress was mainly about. How will this fall into place and how do I deal with it? How can I get both of the things done at the right time? There is more about that. So it was an unpleasant feeling. It was, the feeling was mostly about uncertainty because I didn't really have a certainty about how things will be. I mean, apart from desertation, yes, I was working on it, but the looking for accommodation thing was quite uncertain. So that kind of added up. To both the situations. So that was how it was.

Interviewer (1:43): And when you feel stressed or anxious or anything, how do you first notice that something wasn't right? Like, do you feel it in your chest or is there a mood change or like energy change or something?

P2 (1:48): For me, I think... For me, it's mostly I just stop focusing. I won't be able to focus at all when I get stressed. I can't think about like one thing I can't sit and think straight about. Let's say I'm working on desertation, right? If I have some external stress going on, it'll affect this. I won't be able to focus. I know, I know, and I know that. I won't be able to put my best work out there. So that is the first thing that happens, going out of focus, a little distraction. So I would want to like shut down everything, like close my work, everything, and just be by myself for some time, or maybe like take like a stress nap or something. Or maybe like talk to someone, honestly.

Interviewer (2:45): And talk to someone like who your friends, family.

P2 (2:48): May I just call my best friend, have a chat?

Interviewer (2:53): And if certain like similar, like have you end up using any sort of apps that could have helped you out in this sort of moment or anything like that?

P2 (2:53): I have used like a couple of apps in the past. That was most mainly to reduce my screen time, I would say, because when I have enough work to do, I wouldn't want myself to be wasting time being online. And also about working, coping with like stress better. So I have used like apps before, like a couple of apps, not more, just to like experiment and see how it works out. And yeah, that's pretty much it.

Interviewer (3:33): Have you continued using it?

P2 (3:46): Not really, I used it probably for like a week or two maybe max, not more than that.

Interviewer (3:52): And what led you to not use it?

P2 (3:56): That's the thing. For me, it was more about like experimenting, finding out how, you know, this could maybe build up into like a habit or a routine. But it's just that once I am done with whatever I've been stressed about, let's say once I like maybe... Fix it or get through it. I feel the need to like, okay, get back to whatever I was doing and focus on the next thing that's coming. So I wouldn't really, I would just like try for

the experience to see if it'll, you know, if it helps bring some kind of. Balance, some kind of routine that I could maybe catch up on to, or mainly to like reduce unnecessary like screen time that I would. So the apps would have maybe like some brainstorming games, maybe some tasks, some, you know, like. Stuff like that. So that would basically like calm you down. If your nerves are high, your nerves are up, you basically, if you play those, you know, those little arcade tiny games, little brainstorming puzzles and stuff like that, it kind of helps you like calm down maybe to some extent, I would say, rather than like doom scrolling.

Interviewer (5:14): And have you ever tried to figure out the root cause? Like do you deep dive into it or it's just you let it pass or?

P2 (5:15): Yeah, that's it.

Interviewer (5:22): Like, do you try to understand the code of why it's causing it?

P2 (5:23): I think with me, I don't just let it go. I try to learn and understand what leads to that. But also it's more of like self-convincing myself to feel better, you know, that I...

Interviewer (5:46): Since managing yourself.

P2 (5:50): It's more like I have been through situations like this. I've always gotten out of it. And even this situation might seem too much right now, but then there's always like a way out and then I would eventually figure that out anyway. So basically convincing myself that, yeah, this too shall, you know, it'll pass that way.

Interviewer (6:12): So is it like when it comes to everyday stress, it's more like it'll pass and yeah, things can work out.

P2 (6:12): It's like a little optimism towards myself that, you know, I can get through it. I would get through it. I have in the past and I'll be able to like manage. So something like that, something along that lines.

Interviewer (6:29): And what if you have something that actually tells you like what actually stresses you out and something and I would you be open to like trying that out so that it understands when you stress out and what sort of... Next steps you could take, so.

P2 (6:57): I didn't quite get what you're trying to ask.

Interviewer (7:02): So it's like moreover, everyone knows in their day-to-day life what they're going through, right? Suppose. So if there would be an intervention in which it understands what you're going through at the moment, and it provides you with a solution that could help you in that.

P2 (7:04): Like what understands what I'm going through? Like what do you mean by it?

Interviewer (7:22): So suppose, so suppose like we can take an example of that you are in a situation that you are managing deadlines at the moment, okay, but you don't know how to deal with it. And you're procrastinating and stuff like that. So, but if an app or something can help you understand how to go about it, how to manage it, and how to take one step at a time. Like it's not just for, this is just an example, but if something happens like that, so it also provides you challenges in between. So it keeps you like in focus and helps you go through it and also understand what actually was not working for you.

P2 (8:03): Understood.

Interviewer (8:21): When you are doing it all by yourself, like trying to self-manage it like that.

P2 (8:24): I think for me, like if I predict the example of the app that I tried, right, it does have certain things that it suggests that you could maybe do when you're feeding a certain way. I would take cues from it

definitely, but at the end it would mostly be, I would try it and see if it works. If it works, it works. If it doesn't, it doesn't. And I feel like at the end, it's mostly just doing what I feel like would be the right thing to like calm me down at that point. And I would do that and... You know, it will make the difference. So it's, I think it's mostly a phase where you're stressing out right now and then you have a phase where you're thinking, you know, that it's going to be all, like, you know, you're going to figure it out. I mean, this is basically how it works with me. And then after that, you basically just stop working, stop doing everything for some time. Just relax and then get back to work with like a fresh mind. Maybe like come with a strategy. That's what I do. Like I usually come with a strategy of how I can get this work done. Let's say I'm stressed about some work, right? I form like a whole strategy of how I can finish part by part by part and meet the deadlines with some room remaining for me to like. I can deal with it, this is how I can do, okay, it's going to be all right. And then that kind of gives you a little idea and then you know that, okay, this is how I'm going to deal with this problem right now. And then I get along with whatever work I was doing. So I'll be in like a more calmer state that way.

Interviewer (10:24): Okay, got it. That was pretty much it.

P2 (10:30): That was it.

Interviewer (10:31): That was pretty much it because I just want to understand how you deal with situations when it comes to like when you're stressed out or you're not feeling like at your max. And but also I wanted to understand if you feel stressed. Do you have like a, do you, does that reaction shows in your body or your mind or what happens? Like, do you feel it in your chest or is it like body ache or you're feeling too way too tired or?

P2 (10:55): I feel like physically there isn't much, but definitely I know that my heart rate rises. I don't know if it's like a personal thing because I do have like anxiety issues which has led to that old time. So I'm aware that my heart rate rises. I have fluctuations in my blood pressures. And that's like a personal thing that I've been having. Apart from that, I feel like there's no like chest pain or anything. I would feel a lot tired at that instant, which is why when I like stop doing what I'm doing and then just take some time for myself where I sit and like. Plan, you know, like I said, when I do that, it just gets a little better and I just get back to what I was doing. And sometimes I just, in that time, I just take a quick nap. So I'll feel a little fresh when I wake up. So that's pretty much how I what happens when I'm stressed. Perfect.

Interviewer (12:14): That was pretty much it. Thank you so much, P2. See you. Bye.

P2 (12:16): Sounds good, no worries. You're welcome. Yeah, bye-bye.

Participant P3

Recorded 28 August 2026 · duration 5 min 52 sec · 20 turns retained

Interviewer (0:05): Hi, P3, how are you?

P3 (0:07): I'm good. How about you?

Interviewer (0:09): I'm fine. So I'll be taking an interview regarding, so my topic is regarding a young man's mental health. So I just want to discuss you with you about how like young men go through their everyday stressful moments in their lives and how they cope with it in a way. So I just want to know when was the recent time when you felt like really stressed or frustrated or had a very unpleasant feeling? And what was the time when it was happening? Like, yeah.

P3 (0:45): So recently, like I just switched my job. So at that point of time, it was not a good job. I was doing random stuff. And that was an incident sort of thing that happened. And I was really stressed because the thing is, I have an issue or I have a low sugar thing. So whenever I get anxious. My sugar drops. So I need to force fully have some sugar chocolates or that sort of thing. So at that point of time, that incident happened and I was anxious. I had to take some sugary things and the best possible thing I do is that I have a sort of Playlist for myself that I listen. So I feel good at that point of time. And yeah, I feel I just think about how I came here, what struggle I went through and all those stuff that helps me a lot to calm myself down.

Interviewer (1:29): So as you mentioned that you, when you feel stressed or anxious, your sugar level drops, right? So is that the first sign that you notice when you're anxious or are there different signs like your mood changes or you feel pain in the chest or something like that when you're very stressed?

P3 (1:56): First sign is my sugar drops. The second thing is green fog. Mostly I can't think about stuff. I cannot make any sort of decision at all. And yeah, that's all. And worst case, I might shiver that.

Interviewer (2:13): And at that point, when you like, don't know where to make decisions or what sort of response do you need to have, what keeps you going then?

P3 (2:41): Thing is, I have made a plan for myself. So if I can't help myself while listening to that particular set of music, I just start walking. Oh, I just, I just stop thinking at all and just start walking. I just shut down my phones and everything just. Walk on the grass, that's it, or I do some sort of outside activity. I would say pickleball or any sort of sports, but I just go out, I would say.

Interviewer (3:03): So you go out, like do activities, so you can keep yourself calm. Okay, and if there's a situation in which you are dealing with like a very big amount of stress, would you reach out for help, or is it like you just try to solve it? With yourself, like just self-management sort of thing, or do you actually try to reach out to people?

P3 (3:39): No, I don't. I just do it by myself. I haven't like asked anyone as such. I'm like kind of a very... I haven't shared any sort of thing with anyone. Like, I'm not that kind of person. I haven't tried it. But the thing is, I just start overthinking. But the thing is... That's what I told, actually, if I'm in that particular situation.

Interviewer (4:09): But any particular reason that you have not tried reaching out to people like even in your friends or your family or anything?

P3 (4:19): So yeah, I used to be close with my brother and then he came, he moved abroad. So at that point of time, we had no contact with each other. He just were talking once a week because he was busy. So like I

used to share things with him and then After he moved abroad, I was just alone, so then I started coping up things that I was like doing by myself, then.

Interviewer (4:43): So you self-manage yourself. Has it reached to a stage where it was like, you don't know what to do, like at all, like even it's not self-managing anymore.

P3 (5:02): Nope, not like, no.

Interviewer (5:03): So you are aware when you are like stressed and you try to deal with it. So you have that simple goodness.

P3 (5:09): I. Yeah, but I stopped thinking at that point of time because I know if I do something, it would be the worst decision I'll make.

Interviewer (5:22): Understood. Yeah, so that was it. I just wanted to know how you deal with it and what are your patterns and how do you kind of, what's your coping mechanism? And yeah, that's pretty much about it. So thank you so much, P3. Love talking to you.

P3 (5:45): Welcome.

Interviewer (5:47): So now I'll stop the record.

P3 (5:48): Thank you.